

A mother's medal, a daughter's dream: Inside the Siwach hockey story

Dronacharya Award winner Pritam Siwach built her career fighting odds to play for India. Now, her daughter Kanika carries that legacy forward, **balancing love, discipline and the burden of a famous name** as she chases her own place in hockey history.

Jonathan Selvaraj
jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

Twenty-year-old centre forward Kanika Siwach is one of the mainstays of the Indian junior hockey team, just as her mother, Pritam Siwach (left), was for the Indian team of the 1990s and 2000s. But if Pritam has her way, there will be more generations of Siwaches playing hockey for India.

When she joined the Indian junior women's hockey camp in Bengaluru, Kanika decorated the wall of her hostel room with a collage of posters. That in itself isn't unusual, since many of her teammates have pictures of players they admire and hope to emulate. But Kanika didn't have to look far for motivation. The photographs and magazine pull-outs on her wall are of her own mother, former India international and 2002 Commonwealth Games gold medallist Pritam.

"I put it up so that I can get inspired by them whenever I see it. I get inspired every day. If I'm feeling low, I remember whose daughter I am and whose blood flows in me. If she could do it, so can I," says Kanika,

who is preparing for the Junior Women's Hockey World Cup in December this year.

And if the pictures aren't enough, Pritam is only a phone call away. "We speak every night. Sometimes we discuss hockey, but at other times we simply share our thoughts. We have always been very close. Kanika was born when I was 30, and I was playing international hockey until I was 32, and departmental hockey until much later. When she was very young, I would take her everywhere I went," says Pritam.

With a mother who was a decorated international and is now one of India's most successful coaches (three members of the Indian women's squad that played at the Paris Olympics were trained by Pritam, a Dronacharya Award winner, at her academy in Sonipat), it might have seemed inevitable that Kanika would take up hockey.

But that wasn't a given.

India indeed has its share of multi-generational hockey families. Pritam's son, Yashdeep, has already represented the country internationally. But Pritam and Kanika are among the rare mother-daughter duos to have represented India at any level. Should Kanika eventually earn a senior cap, as many expect, they would become the first mother and daughter to play for the senior national team.



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